

go-bag-checklist

The 72-Hour Go-Bag Checklist™

Build a Grab-and-Go Kit for Every Person in Your Household — Plus the Car

Why this worksheet exists: After a significant earthquake, help may be delayed for 72 hours or longer — stores empty fast, power and water can be out, and roads may be blocked. A go-bag is the single highest-leverage prep action you can take, and yet most “go bags” are really just an old backpack with a granola bar in it. This checklist builds a real one, per person, done right the first time.

How to run it: Build one bag per household member (adjust the list for kids, pets, and elderly/medical needs), plus one car kit. Check off each item as you add it. Set a phone reminder to re-check expiration dates every 6 months (Tool #8 automates this for you).

The master rule: Your bag should let one person survive 72 hours with zero outside help — water, food, light, warmth, communication, and first aid, at minimum.

Section 1 — Water & Food (per person)

- ☐ **Water: 1 gallon per person per day × 3 days** (3 gallons minimum per person) — store in food-grade containers, rotate every 6 months
 - ☐ Water purification tablets or a small filter straw (backup if bottled runs out)
 - ☐ 3 days of non-perishable, no-cook food per person (energy bars, dried fruit, nut butter, canned goods with a pop-top — no can opener needed)
 - ☐ A manual can opener (if any canned food needs one)
 - ☐ Salt/electrolyte packets (heat + stress = dehydration risk)
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Section 2 — Light, Power & Communication

- ☐ Flashlight (LED, per person) + spare batteries stored separately
 - ☐ Hand-crank or battery-powered NOAA weather radio (cell towers may be down; this is your information lifeline)
 - ☐ Portable phone charger/power bank, fully charged, checked quarterly
 - ☐ Whistle (per person — signaling for help without shouting yourself hoarse)
 - ☐ Printed list of emergency contacts (phones die; paper doesn't)
 - ☐ Local paper map (GPS/data may be unreliable — know your area's routes on paper)
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Section 3 — First Aid & Medical

- ☐ Basic first aid kit (bandages, gauze, antiseptic wipes, tape, gloves)
 - ☐ 7-day supply of each prescription medication (rotate as prescriptions refill)
 - ☐ Any medical devices/supplies unique to your household (inhaler, EpiPen, glucose meter + strips, hearing aid batteries)
 - ☐ Pain relievers / anti-diarrheal / basic OTC medicine
 - ☐ Copy of insurance cards and a list of allergies/conditions per person
 - ☐ N95 or dust mask (per person — post-quake dust/debris is a real respiratory risk)
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Section 4 — Warmth & Shelter

- ☐ Emergency thermal blanket (compact, per person)
 - ☐ A complete change of clothes appropriate for your climate, per person
 - ☐ Sturdy closed-toe shoes (you may be walking over broken glass/debris)
 - ☐ Rain poncho (compact, per person)
 - ☐ Work gloves (heavy-duty — for clearing debris safely)
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Section 5 — Cash, Documents & Tools

- ☐ **Cash — small bills.** ATMs and card readers go down with the power grid. \$100–200 in small bills per household is the standard recommendation.
 - ☐ Copies of ID, insurance policies, and important documents in a waterproof bag (or securely backed up digitally on a device that doesn't need the internet)
 - ☐ Multi-tool or basic tool kit (including the wrench for your gas shutoff — see Tool #6)
 - ☐ Duct tape and heavy-duty trash bags (repairs, waterproofing, makeshift shelter)
 - ☐ Fire extinguisher accessible (not necessarily IN the bag, but staged nearby)
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Section 6 — Kids, Pets & Special Needs (add as applicable)

For kids: - [] A comfort item (small toy, photo of family) — reduces panic significantly - [] Extra diapers/formula/wipes if applicable, sized for growth (check every 3 months) - [] A card with the child's name, your contact info, and any medical needs (kids can be separated from parents in a chaotic evacuation)

For pets: - [] 3 days of pet food + collapsible bowl - [] Leash/carrier + copy of vaccination records - [] Pet ID tag with a current phone number

For elderly/medical-dependent household members: - [] Extra mobility aid batteries or backup device if power-dependent - [] Written care instructions a helper could follow if you're incapacitated

Section 7 — The Car Kit (separate from the home bags)

Keep this in the trunk — you may be at work or on the road, not at home.

- ☐ Water + non-perishable snacks (smaller quantity, 1-day supply)
 - ☐ Flashlight + batteries
 - ☐ Emergency blanket + gloves
 - ☐ Comfortable walking shoes (if you commute in dress shoes/heels)
 - ☐ Small first aid kit
 - ☐ Phone charger (car adapter)
 - ☐ Printed emergency contact card
 - ☐ Cash (small bills)
 - ☐ Basic tools + a whistle
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The Verdict Sheet

- **Bags completed:** _____ of _____ household members
- **Car kit completed?** Y / N
- **Water stored (gallons):** _____ (target: 3 per person)
- **Cash on hand (small bills):** \$ _____
- **Prescription meds rotated in bag?** Y / N
- **Next expiration check date (set a reminder now):**

Scorecard: - All bags complete + car kit done: You are in the top tier of prepared households. - Bags 50%+ complete: Good start — finish this weekend, prioritize water and meds. - Just starting: Do ONE thing today — fill 3 gallons of water per person. That alone covers the highest-impact need. Build the rest over the next 2 weeks.

Pro Tips From the Field

1. **Start with water and cash.** If you do nothing else this week, these two items cover the two most common post-quake failures: dehydration and “the store won’t take my card.”
 2. **Store bags somewhere accessible, not in the attic.** A bag you can’t reach after a quake (blocked stairs, jammed door) doesn’t help you. Near an exterior door or in the garage is ideal.
 3. **Rotate food/water every 6 months** — tie it to a date you’ll remember (daylight saving time changes work well as a trigger).
 4. **Pack for “grab and go in under 60 seconds.”** If building the bag takes 10 minutes to assemble during an actual emergency, it’s not a go-bag — it’s a wish list.
 5. **Test the weight.** Each family member should be able to carry their own bag for at least a mile. Adjust kids’ and elderly members’ bags accordingly.
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Your Next Step

You have the checklist. Now execute: fill the water and cash tonight, build the rest of the bag this week, and move to the **Drop, Cover, Hold On Drill (Tool #4)** to train the reflex that matters most in the first 90 seconds. The bag protects the next 72 hours. The drill protects the first 90 seconds — you need both.

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manufacturer guidance for stored supplies and medications.*